

Benchmarking system by system replaced a blanket cost mandate with a focused agenda.

A pre-FEED gas development had been told it was not first quartile, with no evidence of where or why. Two independent benchmarks — top-down against 27 peers and bottom-up to component level — put the gap in pipeline and rig rate, and left production facilities alone.

INDUSTRY	ENGAGEMENT CONTEXT	ROLE	DURATION
Oil & gas — upstream, offshore	Consulting · supermajor upstream operator	Independent competitiveness review (pre-FEED)	4 months

THE SITUATION

- An internal review had flagged costs as outside first quartile, with no like-for-like evidence of where the project actually sat.
- Comparable shallow-water gas peers were scarce, making a credible comparison set the first problem to solve rather than an input to it.
- Without isolating which cost systems drove the gap, the response would default to cutting everywhere.

MY CONTRIBUTION

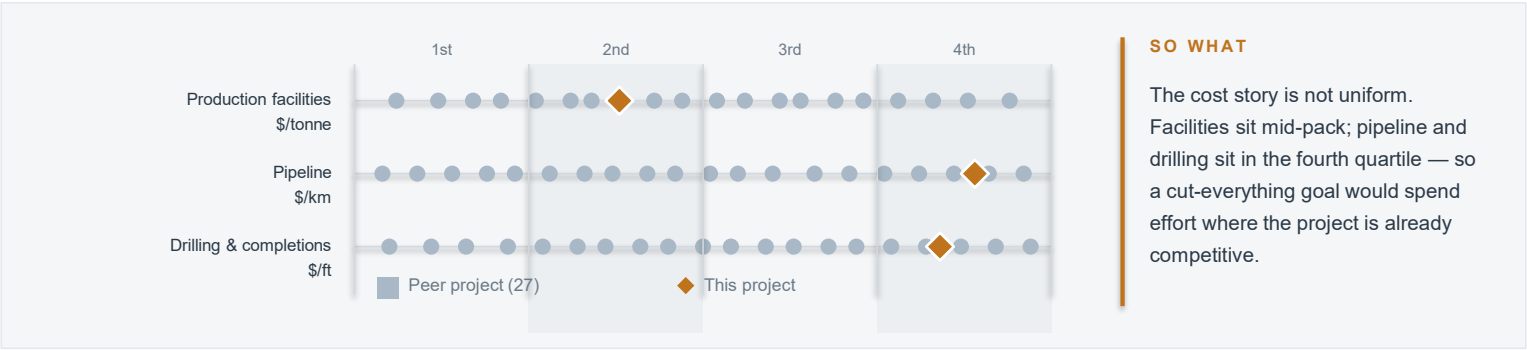
I led the benchmarking workstream feeding a joint gap-to-goal workshop: building the peer set, normalising costs top-down at system level and bottom-up at component level, quantifying the variance, and synthesising a fragmented cost picture into a board-ready verdict — independent of the project team, not a defence of it.

THE JUDGMENT THAT MATTERED

First quartile is not automatically the right goal for every cost system. Separating structural gaps — tie-back distance, seabed conditions, a thin regional contracting market — from commercially addressable ones such as rig rate is what made the benchmark actionable rather than merely damning.

EXHIBIT 1 Peer-group position by cost system

Normalised unit cost vs 27-peer set · directional

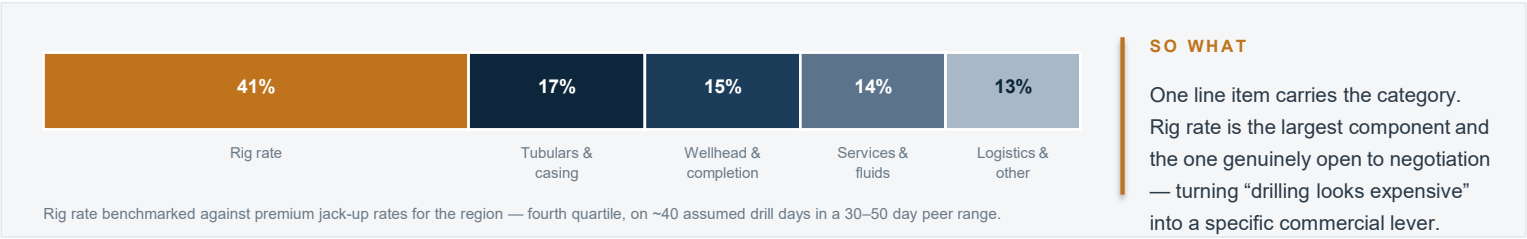


SO WHAT

The cost story is not uniform. Facilities sit mid-pack; pipeline and drilling sit in the fourth quartile — so a cut-everything goal would spend effort where the project is already competitive.

EXHIBIT 2 What actually drives drilling and completions cost

Share of benchmarked D&C cost · directional



SO WHAT

One line item carries the category. Rig rate is the largest component and the one genuinely open to negotiation — turning “drilling looks expensive” into a specific commercial lever.

WHAT THE WORK DELIVERED

- A 27-project peer set built where few ideal comparators existed — the first credible like-for-like cost view available to the decision.
- The dominant lever isolated: rig rate, roughly 41% of drilling and completions cost, sitting in the fourth quartile.

- A system-level verdict — second quartile on production facilities, fourth quartile on pipeline and on drilling & completions.
- The pre-FEED conversation reframed from cutting cost everywhere to a focused, evidence-backed gap-to-goal agenda.

HEADLINE

27 projects

in the comparative peer set

One governance gap repeating six times, not six expensive contractors.

A ~\$230M contractor programme was billing roughly \$5–6M a year above the assessment benchmark. The cause was not which contractors held the work — it was the absence of rate-book enforcement, which meant replacing them would have reproduced it.

INDUSTRY	ENGAGEMENT CONTEXT	ROLE	DURATION
Energy & utilities — electric distribution	Consulting · large US investor-owned utility	Independent commercial assessment (pre-RFP)	6 weeks

THE SITUATION

- A five-year renewal of the overhead-construction contracts was approaching, against a rate book five years out of date.
- Ambiguous work descriptions and time-based billing made the exposure real but unquantified, with no competitive-tension mechanism in the contract.
- Any diagnosis had to pinpoint where governance failed across 482 rate-book items and six contractors without boiling the ocean.

MY CONTRIBUTION

I led the assessment end to end — designing the three-step commercial-impact method, analysing twelve months of approved spend across roughly 565,000 transactions, quantifying above-market billing, isolating its structural root cause, and converting the diagnosis into a five-pillar contracting framework and a phased roadmap tied to the RFP critical path.

THE JUDGMENT THAT MATTERED

A rate comparison is only useful when the work and its measurement units are genuinely comparable. I weighted each contractor's rates by their own transaction volumes, and held the finding together as one integrated opportunity rather than splitting it into a list of individually deniable line items.

EXHIBIT 1 Spend concentration across the rate book

Pareto of the ~\$230M portfolio · directional

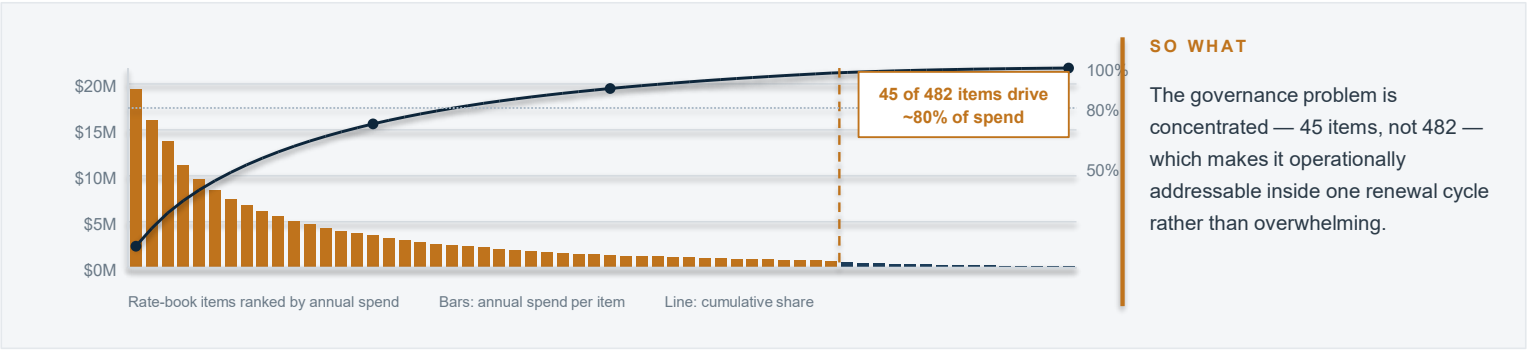
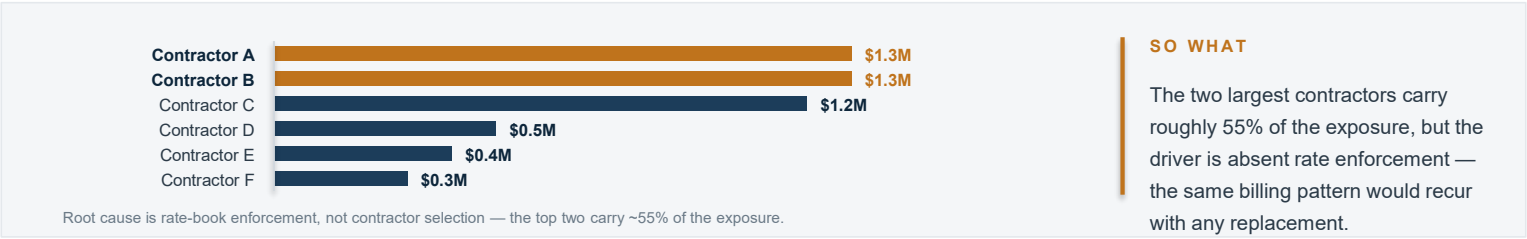


EXHIBIT 2 Above-market variance by contractor

Unit-billing variance vs the weighted-average rate · \$M



WHAT THE WORK DELIVERED

- A ~\$5–6M annual opportunity quantified against the assessment benchmark and shown to be addressable through a single structural lever.
- An RFP-ready toolkit: a five-pillar contract framework, an upgraded work-description standard and a standardised pricing template.

- Rate-book enforcement identified as that lever — avoiding a costly contractor reshuffle that would not have fixed the cause.
- A sequenced roadmap tied to the renewal critical path, each reform mapped to a specific governance failure.

HEADLINE

~\$5–6M

annual opportunity identified

The organisation did not have a level problem — it had a distribution problem.

Headcount ratios would have called this supply-chain function efficient. Assessing workload role by role showed something more useful: a lean structure carrying peer-topping spend per person, with no headroom left for the growth it was being asked to absorb.

INDUSTRY	ENGAGEMENT CONTEXT	ROLE	DURATION
Energy & utilities — regulated electric & gas	Consulting · US energy utility	Organisational benchmarking & operating-model assessment	12 weeks

THE SITUATION

- Leadership needed to know whether the supply-chain organisation was structured to support current spend and planned growth.
- Raw headcount comparisons risked obscuring real differences in role scope and functional coverage between peers.
- The objective was a fact base for workforce and operating-model decisions, not a headcount verdict in either direction.

MY CONTRIBUTION

I led the benchmarking assessment across structure, role allocation and functional capacity — defining the peer-comparison framework, normalising spend and headcount by workload, clustering roles by capability rather than title, reviewing coverage across sourcing, procurement operations, PMO/CoE and planning, and translating the findings into structural implications.

THE JUDGMENT THAT MATTERED

High spend per person can mean a lean organisation or an overloaded one, and the two call for opposite responses. Reading the number alongside scope, service expectations and how execution work was distributed is what turned a benchmark into a recommendation rather than a headline.

WHAT THE WORK DELIVERED

- A structured fact base on supply-chain sizing relative to peers, usable directly in workforce planning.
- Lean enablement and the absence of a standalone planning function identified as the two structural gaps.

EXHIBIT 1 Spend supported per FTE against peer utilities

Peer distribution shown as a box plot · indexed · directional

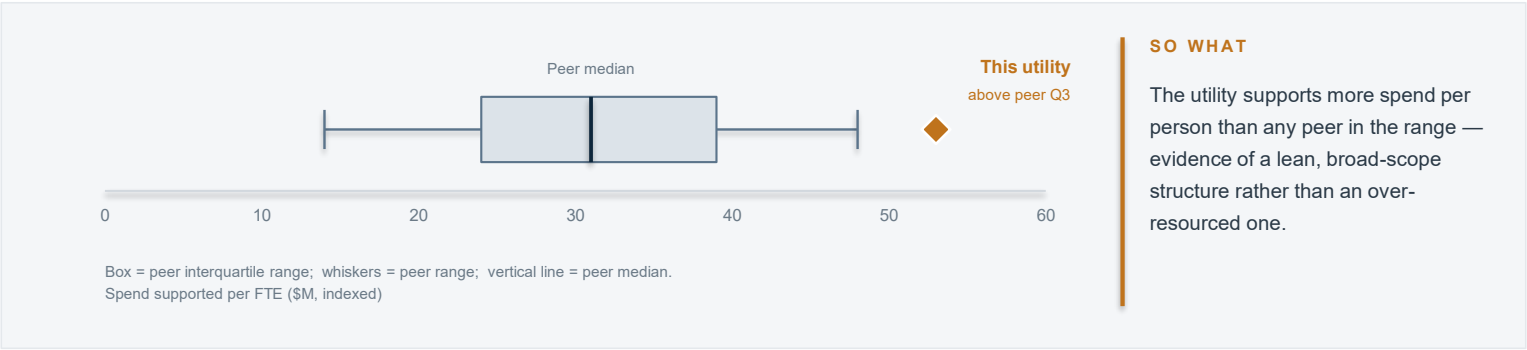
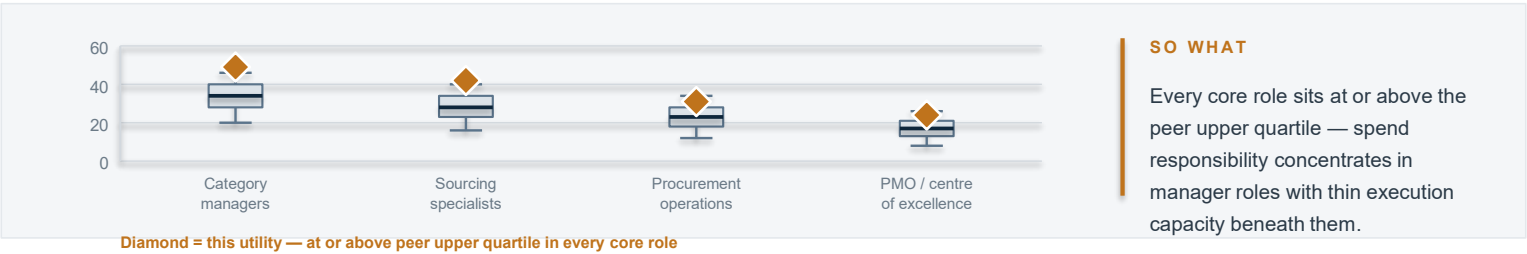


EXHIBIT 2 Spend supported per FTE, by role

Each box = peer distribution · diamond = this utility · directional



HEADLINE

Role by role

supply-chain capacity assessed

The negotiable gap was never in the labour rates — it sat in overhead and margin.

A field-services renewal was on course to roll forward historical rates. Rebuilding the supplier's economics from the cost drivers up moved the negotiation onto what the service should cost, and secured roughly £2M of total-cost optimisation with the incumbent retained.

INDUSTRY	ENGAGEMENT CONTEXT	ROLE	DURATION
Telecommunications	In-house category ownership · BT Group	Category & sourcing manager — renewal and negotiation	6 months

THE SITUATION

- A multi-year regional service-delivery contract was approaching renewal with no refreshed cost baseline behind it.
- Rates had been accepted historically, with no visibility of the supplier's cost build-up, so the renewal risked carrying inflated pricing forward.
- Savings could not come at the cost of continuity — pressing a regional incumbent too hard put field-service delivery at risk.

MY CONTRIBUTION

I led the renewal end to end: building the should-cost model from first principles across labour, productivity, materials, overhead and a fair margin; constructing a total-cost view that priced mobilisation, travel, service-level credits and rework; setting the negotiation strategy and walk-away position; and leading the supplier negotiation to close.

THE JUDGMENT THAT MATTERED

The negotiation that mattered was about complete service economics, not the headline day rate. A lower rate would have meant little if mobilisation, rework or disruption pushed total cost back up — so the ask was sequenced to protect continuity while still taking the margin gap.

WHAT THE WORK DELIVERED

- Approximately £2M of total-cost optimisation locked into the renewed contract across multiple levers.
- A defensible should-cost baseline left with the team, reusable to anchor the next renewal cycle.

EXHIBIT 1 Should-cost build-up against the quoted renewal

Indexed annual cost, by cost element · directional

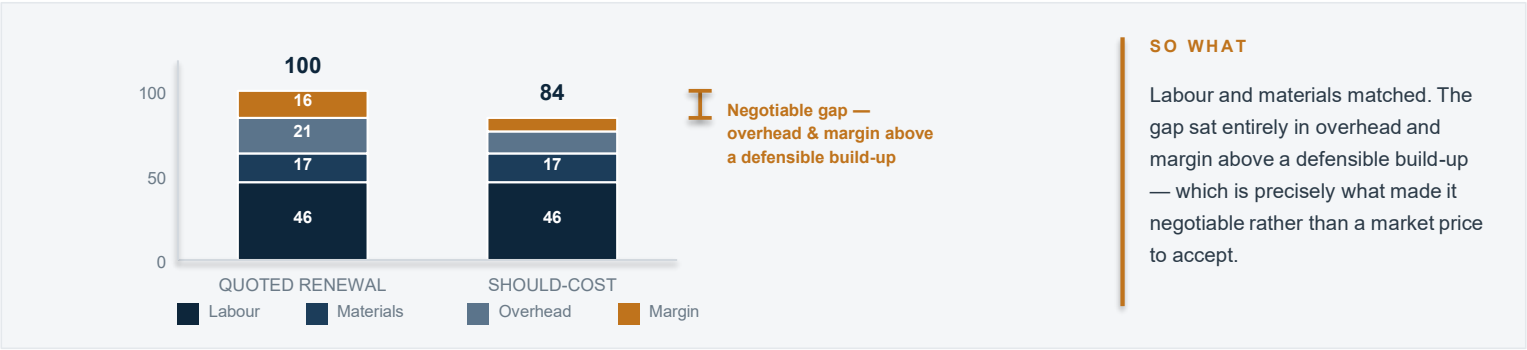


EXHIBIT 2 Total-cost optimisation, quote to signed contract

£M, annual contract value · rounded



HEADLINE

~£2M

total-cost optimisation secured

A capital programme tendered package by package leaks leverage at every award.

Managing the programme as three categories — each matched to its own supply market rather than to one tendering formula — converted scattered tenders into roughly \$4M of CapEx savings and a governance model the client kept.

INDUSTRY	ENGAGEMENT CONTEXT	ROLE	DURATION
Oil & gas — upstream E&P	Consulting · Accenture, upstream E&P operator	CapEx category & sourcing lead	12 months

THE SITUATION

- A large upstream capital programme was being sourced project by project, each package tendered in isolation.
- There was no category strategy and no aggregated demand view, which left limited leverage against a concentrated contractor base.
- Coordination had to arrive without loosening attention on technical requirements, quality and delivery schedule.

MY CONTRIBUTION

Within Accenture's engagement team I led CapEx sourcing and category management across the major spend categories — building category strategies for EPC, surface facilities and drilling & completions; aggregating demand across projects; running sourcing end to end from qualification through award; and embedding category governance in the client's own team.

THE JUDGMENT THAT MATTERED

Leverage came from the structure of the process as much as from the size of the package. A concentrated market does not reward a longer bidder list — it rewards disciplined stage-gates, which is why each category earned a different contracting approach rather than one tendering formula.

EXHIBIT 1 CapEx spend by managed category

Share of the managed capital programme · directional

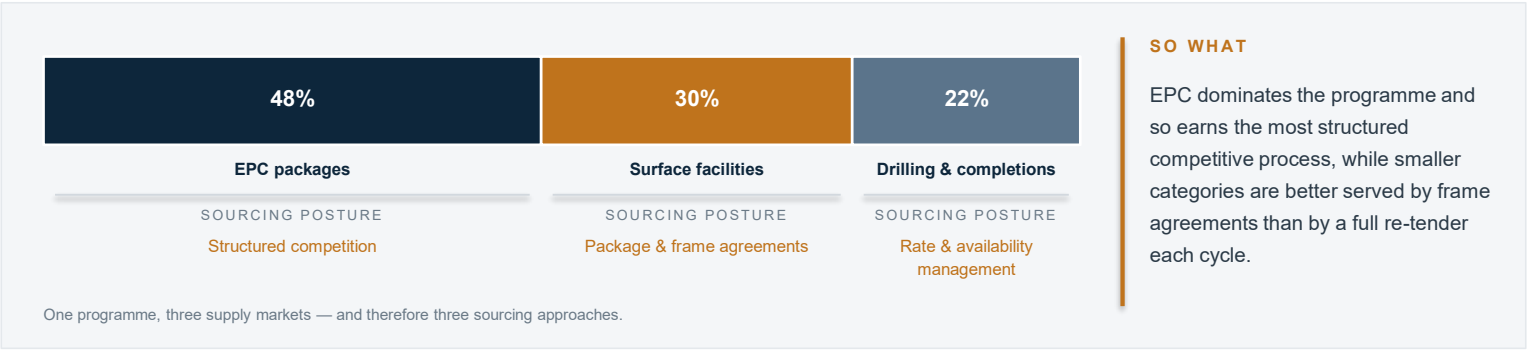
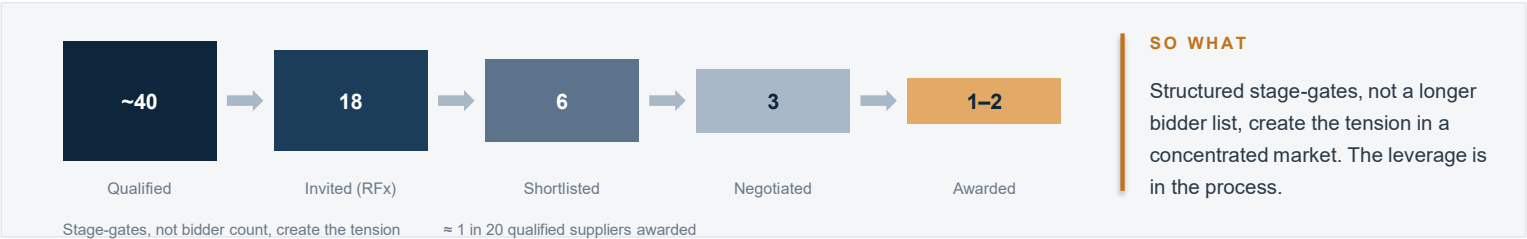


EXHIBIT 2 Sourcing funnel — qualified field to award

Indicative supplier count per major package · directional



WHAT THE WORK DELIVERED

- Approximately \$4M in CapEx savings delivered across the managed sourcing portfolio.
- Demand aggregated across projects to build leverage against a concentrated supplier base.

- Category strategies established across EPC, surface facilities and drilling & completions, replacing project-by-project buying.
- Category playbooks and supplier-management routines embedded with the in-house team.

HEADLINE

~\$4M

CapEx savings delivered

E-STATCOM is a category you secure early, not one you tender late.

Fragmented market, supplier and spend information was reorganised into one decision-ready view of the category. Decomposing cost and lead time into their actual drivers showed why this category rewards partnership and early commitment rather than aggressive competitive tendering.

INDUSTRY	ENGAGEMENT CONTEXT	ROLE	DURATION
Energy & utilities — grid power electronics	Consulting · large US investor-owned utility	Category intelligence & executive briefing	8 weeks

THE SITUATION

- The utility was building a category-intelligence capability; E-STATCOM — grid power electronics with integrated storage — was a priority category.
- The information decision-makers needed was fragmented: supplier data, market intelligence, commodity trends and spend analytics lived separately.
- There was no structured view of the category to support sourcing, capital planning and grid-stability investment.

MY CONTRIBUTION

I built the category-intelligence report end to end on a single analytical framework — market structure, spend profile, supplier landscape and concentration, cost model, commodity exposure, lead-time analysis, contracting approach, risk and supplier KPIs — and iterated the executive summary until every statement was fact-based and decision-relevant.

THE JUDGMENT THAT MATTERED

The shift that mattered was from describing a market to saying what procurement should do about it. I decomposed drivers instead of reporting aggregates: cost broken into its commodity and manufacturing inputs, and lead time separated into its critical-path components rather than quoted as an average.

WHAT THE WORK DELIVERED

- A single intelligence base holding market structure, supplier landscape, cost drivers and lead-time exposure for the category in one comparable frame.
- Cost-driver transparency that lets the client challenge supplier quotes on the inputs that actually moved price.

EXHIBIT 1 Category positioning — risk against business impact

E-STATCOM in the strategic quadrant · directional

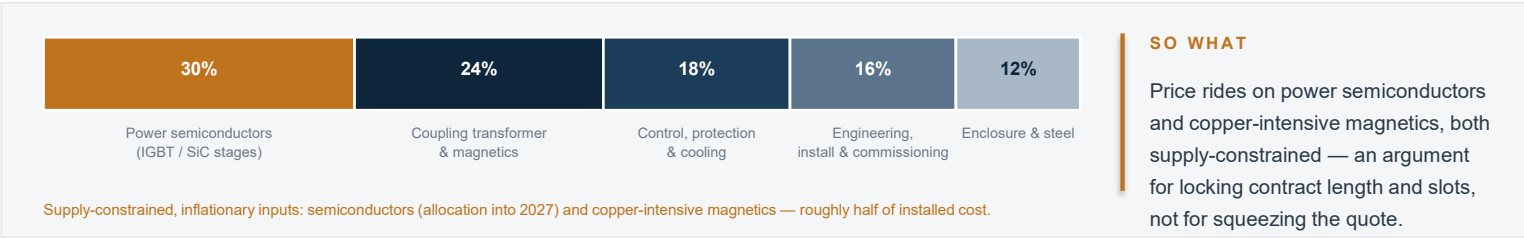


SO WHAT

High supply risk and high impact mean partnership and early commitment, not aggressive tendering. Positioning drives contract length as much as it drives price.

EXHIBIT 2 What moves price in the category

Share of installed E-STATCOM cost · directional



SO WHAT

Price rides on power semiconductors and copper-intensive magnetics, both supply-constrained — an argument for locking contract length and slots, not for squeezing the quote.

HEADLINE

Commit early

the category posture the intelligence pointed to